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Reclaiming Focus: The Necessity of Deep Reading

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Over the last few years, author Tom Corley has asked several self-made millionaires what they do when they first get out of bed in the morning. It's not running, checking their emails, or yoga. Their answers all had a running theme: deep thinking and introspection.

"They invest in themselves in the morning and what do they do? They do things like meditation. They do things like brainstorming," he says. "They're also reading what I call facts. They're studying facts...They're also trying to read uplifting, motivational, inspirational things to get them in the right mindset and this is so important."

In those silent hours where there are no calls begging to be answered, or messages pinging to be replied to, what's left is just them, their thoughts, and the text before them.

Take a deep dive into deep reading

This focused act of deep introspection is especially important when reading, not skimming or browsing, but the slow, meditative, and purposive act of possessing and absorbing a text. In this act, describes Sven Birkerts, "We don't just read the words, we dream our lives in their vicinity. The printed page becomes a kind of wrought-iron fence we crawl through, returning, once we have wandered, to the very place we started."

And for those who have had the immense pleasure of finding themselves similarly enveloped in a book, story, article, or chapter, the results can be transformative.

Everyone reads, of course — a tweet there, a Facebook post, a product review, a news headline. However, not everyone deep reads.

When talking about deep reading, Maryanne Wolf and Mirit Barzillai see it as “the array of sophisticated processes that propel comprehension and that include inferential and deductive reasoning, analogical skills, critical analysis, reflection, and insight.”

It's the curiosity to read between the lines, and to capture and reflect on the hidden details of life's traces from the writer's point of view. It's to possess a modesty to not ask for a fixed interpretation, but trust and dive into the text like a child open to embracing the smallest things, things that are on the surface and things that are hidden to reveal a different world. And the result can literally be life changing.

Reading for increased cognitive function

Multiple studies have determined that reading, in general, engages more cognitive processes in the brain, such as inferential and deductive reasoning, analogical skills, critical analysis, and reflection, all while strengthening brain pathways and increasing the ability to learn and remember new information in the process. And the effects, it seems, last.

In a 2013 study that sought to find out whether reading a novel actually causes measurable changes in the resting-state connectivity of the brain, they discovered that participants' brains retained this heightened connectivity long after they finished reading a book. They did this by scanning participants' brains before, during, and five days after reading a novel. And it stands to reason that deep reading shares the same benefits as well on an even deeper level.

We read to be more connected with others

But beyond these cognitive benefits, to deep read is also an exercise in empathy and compassion. When we deep read, “we literally leave ourselves, our myopic ego, for precious minutes to understand others,” says cognitive neuroscientist and dyslexia specialist, Maryanne Wolf.

When we take the time to deeply read, we can find ourselves connecting with the text in a new way, and this connection helps us to understand the perspectives of others better. “This experience of ‘passing over,’ as it has been called, comes from neural networks in our brain that we use for empathy and compassion.”

Deep reading also helps to develop deduction, inference, and imagination. We use more of our imagination to form mental images of characters, settings, and events described in the text. And we can already make predictions and draw conclusions based on limited information.

Learning the skill of reading again

But in order to receive these benefits, we must first recognize that human beings, contrary to centuries of practice, says Wolfe, were never actually born to read. “We were given a genetic program for language, for vision, for the olfactory system, for touch and cognition. But not for reading. Reading is a human invention and as such, it requires the brain to fashion a new circuit for itself.”

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In fact, many aspects of reading need to be taught. We were all probably too young to remember the actual process of learning how to read, or perhaps we took it for granted because it came naturally for us. However, says Wolfe, “reading is a new cognitive function, invented only 5,500 years ago.”

And there’s also a clear distinction between online and offline reading with different skills acquired and required for each.

For those who have grown up reading mostly online, it tends to reward certain cognitive skills, such as multitasking, immediate information gathering and quick attention shifts — rather than deep reflection and original thought.

And for those so accustomed to it, “the immediacy and volume of available information online may well delude new learners into thinking they have what they need to know.” As such learning to deep read actually requires some practice and a change in habits.

Begin with something you enjoy and take it slow

Whether you simply want to read or dive into deep reading, start with something you already enjoy. If you already have an author you fancy, explore their other works. If there’s a genre you particularly enjoy, visit that section in your local bookstore or its online equivalent to find similar titles. Or if you’re looking for completely new recommendations, bestseller lists are always a good starting point.

To deep read is a journey in slow consumption. In a reading program for students, Wolfe explained how they provided “strategic supports” in the text that the students can engage with to guide them in summarizing what they read. These are prompts to help readers pause and check their comprehension to resist the pull of superficial reading. Adults can do this, too.

When you deep read, make a habit to pause when a passage catches your attention. What is the author trying to say? Why did they phrase it this way? Is there a better way of supporting this point? Would this mean anything in the next few pages or chapters? Some even choose to annotate the text using a pencil, sticky notes, and a separate notebook.

Practice the actual habit of deep reading

When Wolf was trying to wean herself back into deep reading after spending so much time reading online, she forced herself to read every night for 20 minutes. And at the end of two weeks, she was back into her old habit of immersive reading.

“It took me what I call cognitive patience,” she explains. “We all don’t have the same level of cognitive patience that we used to have since we are on the screen. But I found that if I could read at night, after my dinner, after the day is done, and devote about an hour to reading, and then wake up with a book, this has improved my whole day. I feel very much that we are not a lost cause.”

At t2, we hope to provide another medium to help people go beyond their familiar reading habits by creating a thoughtfully designed space where they can read with purpose, intention, and peace. It’s a distraction-free

environment featuring carefully curated content from the best writers surrounded by a community of like-minded readers looking for the same fulfillment in the things they read.

In many studies on reading, they tend to favour physical books rather than devices like smartphones, tablets, and e-readers — mostly because books tend to support more focused reading says Naomi Baron, a professor emerita of linguistics at American University. However, screens aren't always the bad guy.

For the head of the visual and cognitive neuroscience laboratory at the University of Melbourne, Prof Trichur Vidyasagar, "If used correctly and not at the cost of other useful activities, they can greatly benefit learning." It's ultimately a matter of personal preference and how you use that medium.

Ultimately, deep reading is a skill that needs to be developed and nurtured. It requires dedication, patience, and consistent practice to hone this skill.

And while the practice of it takes place within the pages of your book or the screen of your tablet, the real application of deep reading happens when you finish and return to real life now armed with an immense amount of emphatic experience all because you decided to go a little bit deeper than usual.

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Written by Peter Imbong, content creator at t2.

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